

Design an Asian Queer Game through Multimodal Ethnography

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Abstract

Driven by inquiries into both the beneficiaries and processes of critical game design, I seek to employ game design as a means to better represent, empower, and benefit the Asian queer community. I identify the worldbuilding of Asian queer individuals, that is, the processes through which they construct their everyday physical and conceptual spaces, as a crucial dimension of their lived realities, and aim to use the virtual worldbuilding in video games to reflect this real-world worldbuilding. To pursue this goal, I adopt a multimodal ethnographic approach to collect community perspectives and translate them into game content. I have developed an Identify–Participate–Iterate framework to conduct fieldwork, develop game prototypes, and guide iteration. Deliverables expected from this study include a complete game prototype, ethnographic reports, and design documentation. For game studies, this study offers a tangible case of design praxis for inclusion and inspires future practice-based research.

CCS Concepts

• **Applied computing** → Computers in other domains; Personal computers and PC applications; Computer games.

Keywords

multimodal ethnography, identity, game representation, Asian, queer, intersectionality, critical game design

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1 Introduction

Enrolled in a PhD program titled “Critical Game Design,” I have been continually driven by two central questions in my research. On the one hand, I am concerned with the question: for whom are we designing games? While playing games has appeared to be a universal human phenomenon transcending geographic, cultural, and identity boundaries [1], contemporary digital game cultures are not ideally equitable or diverse [2]. Throughout my global academic

journey, I have observed that different cultures and communities often hold distinct preferences for games, play styles, and artistic expressions they regard as “mainstream.” Instead of evaluating which forms of gameplay are more mainstream, my interest lies in bridging diverse understandings of games and play, and in bringing the overlooked ones to a broader audience through game design.

On the other hand, I also inquire into what makes game design “critical.” Scholarly discussions of digital games emerged almost in parallel with the rise of the Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) field, and over time, these discussions have expanded far beyond gameplay and technology to encompass more critical topics, such as games’ social impact, political contexts, and their serious applications. Yet many critical game studies remain at the level of analysis and lack design praxis, thus struggling to generate alternative designs [3]. Admittedly, when compared to the flourishing game industry, academia’s strengths do not lie in investment, manpower, or even technology. Therefore, critical game design demands the integration of methodologies from practical HCI, sociology, and potentially other disciplines, so that the research outcome can both guide game design and preserve a critical academic perspective.

With these two questions in mind, for my dissertation project, I shift my attention to the Asian queer community, which I belong to. Due to the intersectional nature of this identity, the voices of Asian queer people are often overlooked in media content that focuses on either Asian people or queer people [4, 5]. Then, as a response, I aim to critically design a game to better represent, empower, and benefit this community. In what follows, I further explain the context of this study.

2 Background

2.1 Video games, identity, and representation

Video games often draw on characteristics of real-world social identities to design characters, narratives, mechanics, and other elements. These elements can then be understood as a form of identity representation. Despite that representations are not facts, the way video games invite players to embody these representations makes them double-edged swords with tangible impact. On the one hand, game representations often inherit societal stereotypes and neglect of marginalized communities [6], and serve as pedagogical material to reinforce cultural biases among players [7]. On the other hand, intersectional and nuanced representations of multiply marginalized groups can render their identities more visible and legible [8]. In other words, game representations are sites where intersectional marginalization manifests, but can also serve as a means to address such marginalization.

Since the inception of video games, the dominant demographic in game culture has long been heterosexual, cisgender white men

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[2, 9]. Considering that other groups, such as Asian cultures and the queer community, also possess long-standing and distinct histories of gaming [10, 11], the dominance within game culture ultimately reflects an authority to define, select, and interpret what counts as games and play. As a result, disadvantaged groups in society, such as women, people of color, and queer individuals, are often misrepresented and further marginalized in game culture as well [12]. Although game companies have begun to pay more attention to identity issues in games as societal consensus evolves, this attention often reflects a commercially driven response to an increasingly diverse player base and leads to an increase in representation quantity rather than depth [8, 13]. Under these circumstances, the call for critical game design is never merely about increasing the quantity of representations. Instead, it demands that game design incorporate a wealth of authentic and often overlooked details about marginalized people's lived experiences, including their challenges, lifestyles, needs, values, and more.

2.2 Asian, queer, and worldbuilding

In this study, I approach the lived experiences of Asian queer people from the perspective of worldbuilding, a term that carries a triple meaning here. Firstly, it points to the physical locations Asian queer individuals encounter as a result of their daily activities, aligning with the concept of activity space in geography [14]. The differences in activity space across identity groups can reveal social inequalities regarding transportation, segregation, and resources [15], which can also offer foundational insights into the ways we understand Asian queer lives. Secondly, worldbuilding also encompasses the affective, imaginative, and communicative ways in which Asian queer people understand and interact with their lived environment [16]. For instance, Eng argues that Asian and queer identities harbor similar yearnings for a “home”, that is, a conceptual space where they feel a sense of belonging [4].

Last but not least, worldbuilding is also a fundamental concept in game design. Since gaming activities are commonly regarded as taking in alternative worlds with alternative time and space [17, 18], every aspect of game design, whether it is about mechanics, narratives, or arts, can be understood as an endeavor to construct alternative virtual worlds. Therefore, the virtual worldbuilding in video games has the potential to reflect the real-life worldbuilding of Asian queer individuals as their everyday realities. Framing worldbuilding as the central theme of this study then not only calls for attention to both the embodied and emotional experiences of Asian queer people, but also invites a holistic consideration of the multiple aspects of game design.

3 Methodology

3.1 Research questions

In the previous sections, I have discussed the significance of valuing identity considerations and design-based research in critical game design. Additionally, I have identified Asian queer people as the focal group of this study and worldbuilding as the central theme that connects their lived experiences to game design. Based on these insights, I propose the core research question of this study:

(RQ) **How can we represent the worldbuilding experiences of Asian queer people through critical game design?** To address

this research question, the following sub-questions must also be answered to streamline the design process:

- (rq1) What are the Asian queer community's expectations for game design? What aspects of games (arts, narratives, mechanics, and interfaces) are they concerned about?
- (rq2) How does the Asian queer community in the US navigate through their everyday world? What kinds of symbolic importance are attached to particular landmarks and activities?
- (rq3) How to translate the worldbuilding experiences of Asian queer individuals into game content in ways that ensure their voices are meaningfully amplified?

3.2 Multimodal ethnography

There have been extensive research cases in the HCI field that design for marginalized identities. In design-based game research, studies with similar aims often build upon these cases, adopting methods such as co-design workshops, surveys, and interviews to integrate insights from the target group into the design process [19, 20]. However, as [21] has shown, these methods are generally small in size and time scales, which can potentially reduce the representational depth of fieldwork outcomes. For themes such as identity representation and everyday worldbuilding, this then calls for methodological refinements that can capture in-depth accounts of participants and attend to multimodality.

Speaking of methodologies that require long-term fieldwork and close investigation, ethnography is impossible to overlook. That being said, for ethnography to serve the goals of game design, its processes of data collection, analysis, and reporting need to be adapted while still maintaining commitment to “documenting what actually goes on” in real life [22, p.4]. I refer to this adapted methodology as multimodal ethnography for game design. The term multimodal ethnography has been used to describe ethnographic works that consider multimedia resources “for conducting fieldwork, for aiding analysis and, most challengingly, for representing their completed work” [23, p.77]. Yet presenting ethnographic work in media other than writing, especially in contemporary interactive media, is still not common in academic praxes. In game studies, recent years have seen the emergence of design-oriented ethnographic research [24], in which scholars build games “to facilitate a reflexive anthropological engagement with real-world issues” [25, p.104]. Building on these studies, I argue that the multimodal ethnography in this study should (1) consider the relationship between participants and game/play during ethnographic fieldwork, (2) diversify the communication approaches beyond traditional ethnography, and (3) gather and integrate participant data in multimodal forms.

3.3 The IPI research framework

Drawing on the discussions above and the critical play design model proposed in [26], I have developed an **Identify - Participate - Iterate (IPI) research framework** to systematically implement multimodal ethnography (see Figure 1). Each term in the IPI framework represents a research phase with corresponding objectives and methods. In the Identify Phase, I will employ focus group playtesting to gather the Asian queer community's opinions on existing game representations of Asian and queer identities, and

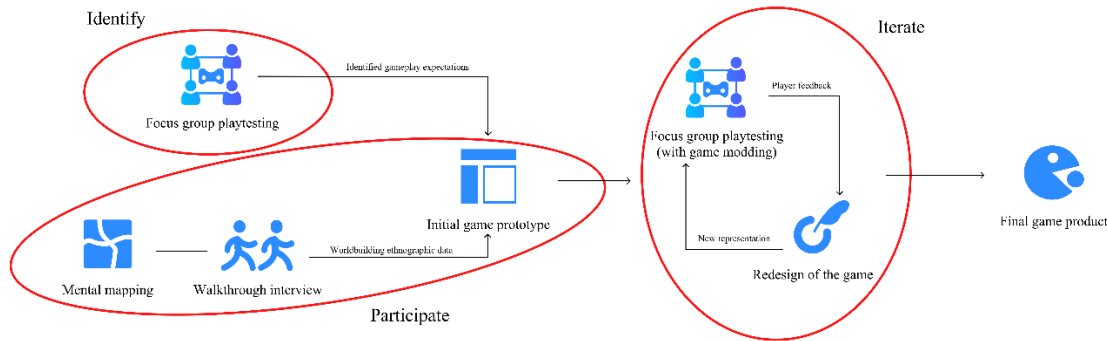


Figure 1: The Identify - Participate - Iterate (IPI) research framework

more importantly, to identify their expectations and needs for intersectional game design. Next, in the Participate Phase, I will use mental mapping and walkthrough interviews to generate ethnographic data regarding Asian queer individuals' daily navigation experiences. These ethnographic data, along with the previously identified expectations, will then be categorized into four gameplay dimensions (i.e., narratives, arts, mechanics, and interface) to guide the development of the initial game prototype. Finally, in the Iterate Phase, I will collaborate with Asian queer individuals to go through several rounds of the playtesting-redesign loop, during which participants' feedback and modification insights will be considered to develop the final game product.

I have identified the National Association of Asian American Professionals (NAAAP) Boston Pride Chapter and Chinese Rainbow Network (CRN) as the two major Asian queer communities to engage with in this study. All individuals who self-identify as Asian queer and are aged 18 and above are welcome to participate in any of the research phases. Among the three phases, the Identify Phase and Participate Phase will take place simultaneously, followed by the Iterate Phase. The total fieldwork and game design period is estimated to be 18 months between July 2025 and December 2026. To summarize, the IPI framework responds to the research questions of this study and ensures the multimodal ethnography remains critical, structured, and complete.

4 Research PRogress

4.1 Fieldwork report

The fieldwork of the Participate Phase, including mental mapping and walkthrough interviews, began in the summer of 2025. For each mental mapping session, I invited participants (through Zoom or physically) to draw their daily activity spaces they encounter on a blank canvas, using the basic items such as paths, regions, and reference points. Following this, participants were also asked to explain their map and share their experiences navigating the spaces. As for each walkthrough interview, I requested one participant from the Greater Boston Area to guide me through the neighborhood they traverse daily in a casual atmosphere. During the walkthroughs, I then conducted semi-structured interviews

with participants, asking why and how they understand this neighborhood as an important slice of their everyday experiences. More importantly, being physically present in these spaces has allowed me to directly observe the living environment and the interpersonal interactions within it.

As the fieldwork unfolded, several themes of Asian queer lived experiences began to emerge. One particularly important theme is food. For my participants, the everyday practices of acquiring, preparing, and consuming food speak simultaneously to their Asian and queer identities. On the one hand, there is a notable difference between Asian and Western food cultures, which makes food not merely a means of survival but a composite of culture, morality, and social norms [27]. On the other hand, reconstructing cooking responsibilities and rules also serves queer individuals as a means of challenging domestic norms historically shaped by cisgender heterosexual households [28]. Moreover, cooking also provides a personal and safe space through which queer individuals could foster belonging and intimacy. Besides food, other major themes that emerged included community building and family. Collectively, these themes reveal both the needs and strategies of participants negotiating their intersectional position as Asian queer individuals. In a broader sense, these themes also illustrate the everyday agency of Asian queer people, which offers valuable guidance for representing such agency through the notion of game agency in my later design practice.

4.2 Future work

In 2025, I will continue the ethnographic fieldwork described above, with the goal of completing at least fifteen mental mapping sessions and five walkthrough interview sessions by the end of the year. Additionally, I also plan to complete at least four sessions of the focus group playtesting in the Identify Phase. For each playtesting session, I will invite 3-5 Asian queer individuals to participate in each session to playtest two 20-minute clips from games *Dream Daddy* [29] and *Persona 5 Royal* [30], which respectively present a protagonist's everyday life perspectives through the lens of Asian and queer identities. These clips will then facilitate a follow-up focus group discussion, during which I will encourage participants to engage in dialogue about their gaming practices and their opinions on Asian queer game content.

Beginning in early 2026, I will spend six months on intensive game prototype development, exploring how to transform the collected participant data into game content. This will be followed by the Iterate phase, during which I will invite Asian queer individuals to playtest the existing prototype and collaboratively determine how the game should iterate. In the final playtesting session of the Iterate phase (December 2026), I will focus on how the participating Asian queer individuals experience and interpret the game, and whether they find strength and solace through gameplay. The feedback from these final test participants, the streamlined game design, and the creative insights generated by participants across earlier research phases will together form a triangulation that validates the findings of this study.

5 Conclusion

In our contemporary era, there is an increasing societal recognition of the contributions and importance of marginalized communities, a shift also reflected in the evolution of digital media technology. However, for intersectional identities such as Asian queer individuals, there is still a long way to go. Especially for video games, efforts addressing the lack of intersectionality remain insufficient, and this study is a firm and direct response to the situation. For the Asian queer community, the game produced in this study will allow them to see themselves, enhance their sense of identification, and find a “home” within the universal activity of play. For the academic field of game studies, the preparation, procedures, compromises, and successes that emerge in this study will encourage more research practice to move beyond critique and actively integrate design. For the broader gamer community, the game will foster a more comprehensive understanding of the lives of Asian queer individuals, contributing to reducing stereotypes and fostering diversity on a societal level. After all, understanding and presenting how marginalized communities engage with game and play is not only a matter of social justice, but a refusal to accept narrow and homogenized visions of gaming, and a reclamation of the possibilities to enjoy all kinds of alternative experiences through gameplay.

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